

Frankenstein's adaptive chain: from fidelity to promiscuity to adultery

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Abstract

Because different media require different narrative approaches, no adaptation can ever be truly faithful to its source material; however, not all unfaithful adaptations demonstrate the same degree of dis-loyalty to their antecedent(s). Instead of simply approaching adaptations in terms of their intertextuality, I propose approaching adaptations in terms of a spectrum of fidelity, one that extends from “faithful” to “promiscuous” to “adulterous.” Using Mary Shelley’s 1818 novel *Frankenstein* and its myriad adaptations as case studies, I present in this essay not only my case for infidelity studies but also argue the value of taking such an approach and using such vocabulary. As adaptation studies has engaged in the language of fidelity almost from the beginning—and thus embraced the metaphor of a marriage in terms of an adaptation’s relationship with its primary source text—I argue for an expansion of that metaphor, one that will afford students, critics, and theorists alike more ways to discuss degrees of in/fidelity.

Keywords: adaptation; unfaithful; *Frankenstein*; promiscuous; adulterous

When most people think of *Frankenstein*, they likely think of iconic imagery from the 1931 James Whale film and not details from Mary Wollstonecraft Shelly’s original 1818 novel. A room full of scientific equipment, nasty-looking switches, and arcing electrical currents? Whale. A dramatic lightning storm and a hunchbacked lab assistant? Whale. A Creature with green skin, a pronounced forehead, and contact bolts on his neck?¹ Whale (and to a greater extent, makeup artist Jack Pierce). Because so many modern and recent adaptations and iterations of *Frankenstein* exist—in film, on television, and even on cereal boxes—the vital question about the creative process should not be *how* Shelley’s novel is being adapted but instead *what*, in fact, is being adapted (see Newell, “Oz Adaptations,” 80). Whale’s influential production design, Pierce’s makeup work, Colin Clive’s manic performance as “Henry” Frankenstein, and Boris Karloff’s memorable appearance as “The Monster” have come to define the concept of “Frankenstein” for most people instead of Shelley’s novel. However, what these same people may not realize is that Whale’s film itself was not merely an adaptation of Shelley’s *Frankenstein* but instead an intertext, the product of an adaptive chain of *other* adaptations and transformations, additional versions of the source novel that only gradually transformed Shelley’s work

from its original identity into what would become Whale's movie, an intertextual chain that comprised multiple theatrical adaptations and one earlier filmic turn, each contributing different manipulations of Shelley's novel.

For Shelley's "hideous progeny"—as she affectionately called her novel in her introduction to its 1831 third edition (Shelley, "Introduction," 221)—to continue to exist through the centuries, it had to evolve, like a biological organism, into a version of itself better adapted (pun intended) to survive from generation to generation. Instead of the celebrated (and forever illusive) "faithful" adaptation seemingly preferred by so many fans, I suggest *Frankenstein* had to be adapted more liberally to provide non-literary audiences with alternative forms of access, specifically the re-telling of Shelley's story on stage and later on the screen. This approach to an adaptation admittedly embraces a reconsideration of the work in terms of fidelity, a discourse that has almost unanimously been rejected by adaptation theorists (see Leitch 103). Instead of analyzing and evaluating an adaptation in terms of its relationship to its acknowledge antecedent, the overwhelming trend in adaptation studies today focuses on adaptations as intertextual constructions; Thomas Leitch goes so far as to suggest that the study of adaptation is, in fact, a "subset of intertextuality," for "all adaptations are obviously intertexts" (89). Furthermore, Kate Newell argues that "[d]ifferent versions of works rewrite, revise, and expand certain details of previous iterations" through adaptation's "manifestation of intertextuality" (6). As my discussion of *Frankenstein* will show, all versions of the famous novel (including the famous novel itself) are intertextual, and I agree such an approach is essential for adaptation studies in general (and for this text cluster in particular).

However, with this article I hope to demonstrate that a consideration of fidelity remains a useful way to approach an adapted work. I propose we step back to the early days of adaptation studies with an updating of the very concept of fidelity; specifically, as adaptation studies has long deployed the terms "faithful" and "fidelity" in its analysis of adaptations, I suggest taking the "adaptation as marriage" metaphor even further, recognizing these kinds of adaptations—that is, those that only make the changes to the source material required of another medium while remaining otherwise loyal to the source's characters, story, and plot—be best understood in terms of "promiscuous adaptation." While not the kind of adaptive "cheating" that would lead to an end of the metaphorical marriage (that is, a "divorce" between the source text and the adaptation under consideration), promiscuity represents more of a "flirtation" with other forms of storytelling, making just minor changes in narrative elements such as character names, specific dialogue, some plot details, etc—not to mention duration, story structure and execution, and overall messaging—while maintaining a direct connection with the source, usually via its "married name": in this case, a title with some variation on "*Frankenstein*."

While the 1931 *Frankenstein* film proved to be a powerful beneficiary of multiple promiscuous trysts—itsself becoming the chief narrative antecedent of so many later iterations of the *Frankenstein* story and its Creature (as with Mel Brooks's *Young Frankenstein* [1974], for example)—the journey of Shelley's progeny hardly ended there. After Whale's film, the text of "*Frankenstein*" continued to grow and evolve, adding new elements and qualities, such as new characters, new plot developments, and new metaphorical significance, often made possible by new technologies, new audience expectations, and new narrative sequels. Elements from the early promiscuous evolutions would continue to

appear in later adaptations, often with *additional* variations, thus continuing the complex chain of adaptive efforts from Whale's film(s) to the present day. As these adaptations were often forced to contend with even more competition—in terms of horror narratives, cinematic storytelling, and other versions of *Frankenstein*—they needed to evolve even more aggressively to prove themselves “the fittest.” I suggest the most radical adaptive efforts be considered “adulterous” in terms of their relationship with Shelley's original source material. Such texts often *do* divorce themselves from the *Frankenstein* name completely, perhaps even cutting Shelley's characters, plot elements, and overall significance as well. These adaptations often only preserve the concept of an entity that has been created by means other than biological reproduction, with “variations on a theme” that have allowed these retellings to survive and even thrive in new historical or cultural environments.

Rather than embracing a simple binary of fidelity as a means of analyzing and evaluating an adaptation—that is, whether an adaptation is faithful to its source text or not—I propose categorizing adaptations along a *spectrum* of fidelity, one that unabashedly embraces the marriage metaphor with degrees of faithfulness within the relationship. The most fidelitous adaptations should continue to be seen as “faithful” to their antecedent “spouse.” Those that stray from the path of total commitment can be seen as being “promiscuous” vis-a-vis their narrative partner, remaining closely allied but clearly not fully faithful. Finally, those adaptations that make such drastic “adulterous” moves against their one-time narrative spouse have, for the most part, abandoned all attempts at fidelity, resulting in some cases in a seemingly new text, one completely divorced from its erstwhile antecedent yet nonetheless identified as having once been in such a creative partnership. I suggest this spectral model of adaptation studies would allow both theorists and students alike a more descriptive, flexible, and accessible vocabulary and metaphorical structure by which to discuss, analyze, and evaluate adaptations in terms of their relationships to their source materials. Furthermore, acknowledging a spectrum of fidelity could allow more texts to be recognized and understood in terms of one (or more—“bigamous adaptations”?) otherwise unacknowledged antecedents, broadening the scope of adaptation studies in general. While I am using *Frankenstein* as my case study, this theoretical framework could be applied to any pervasive text system, those texts that constitute what Newell calls “cultural phenomen[a]” (*Expanding Adaptation Networks* 2).

Frankenstein's Adaptive Chain

Dennis R. Cutchins and Dennis R. Perry call the seemingly never-ending proliferation of *Frankenstein* adaptations the “Frankenstein Network,” a cluster of related, interrelated, and intertextual texts, each connected to Shelley's novel in their own ways (1). And while each new version of *Frankenstein* has obvious ties to Shelley's original work, they are perhaps influenced even more by all the *other* versions of *Frankenstein* that have appeared during the intervening years. While no adaptor could possibly be intimately familiar with every iteration of *Frankenstein*, those that are intellectually present (whether intentionally or unintentionally) act as an unavoidable element of the adaptive process, with some texts bearing more weight than others. As Pamela Demory has written concerning Jane Austen's *Pride and Prejudice* and its myriad adaptations, *all* adapted works must be read as having “some kind of intertextual relationship with the prior versions—hypertexts of the

novel—and with other associated cultural phenomena,” resulting in a metaphorical “thick tapestry” including the antecedent novel, various filmic and literary adaptations, genre conventions, expectations, and market forces (123). In other words, “there are any number of paths through a text, each potentially a source for an adaptation” (Albrecht-Crane and Cutchins 8). As adaptations are increasingly influenced by forces other than the original source material, they will inherently become less and less faithful, much in the same way a photocopy of a photocopy will bear increasingly fewer similarities with the original document.

With such a cluster of adaptive plays, films, novels, and television shows existing within the Frankenstein Network, using fidelity as a standard of quality for evaluation and analysis will forever fall short, as *Frankenstein* adaptations are always already unfaithful to Shelley’s original novel, at least to some degree. Cutchins and Perry emphasize how the unavoidable influence of an increasing number of adaptations—along with personal encounters and interpretations—will only drive any new adaptation further from the source: “when someone experiences a new *Frankenstein* adaptation,” they claim, “acknowledged by the creators or otherwise, the meanings they apprehend are automatically filtered through the internal and personal palimpsest of other ‘Frankensteins’ they have experienced” (6). These “palimpsestic adaptations” are part of what Cutchins and Perry call the “Frankenstein Complex,” texts that represent one’s personal experience with *Frankenstein*, based on previously consumed versions of the story (likely including Shelley’s novel), the ever-growing collection of variations constituting the Frankenstein Network (6).

Even though the viewers of filmic adaptations tend to focus on issues of fidelity—that is, whether the film meets their expectations in terms of a filmic version of the source material, preferably with as few variations as possible—adaptation theorists emphasize the impracticality of such a myopic focus. However, because of the palimpsestic nature of adaptations—texts that are both their own (original) things *and* works related to other works—Linda Hutcheon emphasizes that “proximity or fidelity to the adapted text” should *not* be the primary “criterion of judgment or the focus of analysis” because of this “double nature” of an adaptation (6). In other words, every adaptation must be considered as both itself *and* the inheritor of at least some kind of intertextual legacy. Foundational adaptation scholar Robert Stam also stresses the problematic nature of fidelity, pointing out how “an adaptation is automatically different and original due to the change of medium” (55). A filmic retelling of a novel could never be fully faithful (and certainly not “accurate”) because the fundamental method of telling a story differs from medium to medium, including plays, movies, graphic novels, video games, television shows, and other novels. Yet even these written, literary retellings of *Frankenstein* can never be truly faithful either because, as film theorist Dudley Andrew makes clear, all adaptations are “new artistic signs” that merely “bear the original as a signified”; in many ways, then, adaptations can never be more than merely references to the original work(s) (96).

With the consensus of theorists seeming to decry any preoccupation with fidelity as a standard of evaluation for adapted texts, I suggest a valuable scholarly path forward to be more intentional investigations of *infidelity*—yet never in a vacuum, as the source signifier remains an essential signified for the new work to be recognized as an adaptation in the first place. With the ubiquitous existence of the Frankenstein Complex always already in play, the question isn’t merely the *degree* of fidelity from one adaptation to the

next but also the true *nature* of the fidelity. With so many modern *Frankenstein* adaptations, Shelley's novel may not, in fact, be the true antecedent; other versions, variations, and adaptations of *Frankenstein* may be exerting a greater influence on authors, illustrators, and filmmakers than any edition of Shelley's novel. The tale of the overreacher who creates biological life without following the natural procreative process was almost immediately betrayed by adaptors after its inception, and those adaptations have shaped the future of the Frankenstein Network more than any other source or inspirational text.

The three categories of fidelity/infidelity I introduced above align, for the most part, with Andrew's adaptive modes of intersecting, borrowing, and transforming (98–104).² A "faithful" adaptation stays largely committed to the source text, albeit making some changes and alterations to account for a different medium, a shorter duration, a shift in audience, or a change in culture or time period.³ This type of adaptation is akin to Andrew's "intersecting," which he describes as "a refraction of the original," a recreation of the source text in which "the uniqueness of the original ... is preserved to such an extent that it is intentionally left unassimilated in adaptation" (99). In other words, these types of adaptations strive to retain as many recognizable links to the source work as possible. *Frankenstein* adaptations of this sort present themselves as filmic versions of Shelley's novel and include "unassimilated" elements from the original text, such as the title, the names of the main characters, key story points, and the general plot structure. Taken from this perspective, Kenneth Branagh's 1994 *Mary Shelley's Frankenstein* may take the prize for faithfulness, with its inclusion of Shelley's frame narrative, the character of Captain Walton (Aidan Quinn), the articulate intelligence of the Creature (Robert De Niro), and the narrative's conclusion—although it takes *substantial* liberties with the side story of Elizabeth (Helena Bonham Carter) and the so-called "Bride of Frankenstein" (denying the film status as fully faithful).

Andrew's mode of "borrowing" has the most in common with my conception of the "promiscuous" adaptation and represents the majority of *Frankenstein* adaptations that bear the same (or similar) title as Shelley's novel. I think of a promiscuous adaptation as one that overtly presents its ties to the original material—including details such as the title, the primary characters, the main narrative elements, and perhaps even the general time period—but takes notable liberties in terms of story, plot, theme, tone, and perhaps even the genre. Promiscuous adaptations include most of the stage plays, Whale's Universal films, the *Frankenstein* movies from the Hammer film studio, Brian Aldiss's novel *Frankenstein Unbound* (1973), Marvel Comics's *The Monster of Frankenstein* run (1973–75),⁴ Brooks's parody *Young Frankenstein*, and even Fred Dekker's *The Monster Squad* (1987). While such adaptations work artistically as reinterpretations and cultural/historical evolutions of Shelley's novel, they are also unabashedly taking advantage of an established, successful, and open-source intellectual property. In terms of the marriage metaphor, these texts may not be "happily married" to their antecedent partners, but they remain in the union to take advantage of their partner's name, reputation, and security. For example, Andrew emphasizes how his idea of borrowing describes an adaptation that not only employs "the material, idea, or form of an earlier, generally successful text," as I have described above, but also with the hope of winning "an audience by the prestige of its borrowed title or subject" (98). These products are commodities as much (if not more) as they are

art, often designed to “cash in” on the *Frankenstein* name while also affording the creators sufficient creative license to pursue their own artistic—and other—agendas.

The least faithful kind of adaptations refuse any direct connection with an inspirational antecedent, failing to indicate or cite a preexisting authorial influence, and are thus what I call “adulterous” adaptations.⁵ By departing so intentionally from the source material, these works represent a kind of “transforming,” Andrew’s adaptive mode that exists in two distinct ways: investing faithfully in either truth to the “letter” or to the “spirit” of the original text (100). Here’s where I think Andrew’s system becomes murky and far less useful, for his category of “transforming” seems to describe both faithful *and* unfaithful adaptations at the same time. That is, staying true to the letter would actually include the most fidelitous adaptations—how, then, does transformation differ from intersection in Andrew’s categories? His idea of a “spiritual transformation,” those adaptations that adhere merely to the spirit of the source rather than the letter, does sound more like adulterous adaptations, for they transform not the characters, geography, or cultural information but instead focuses on tone, values, imagery, and rhythm (100), but if “transformation” can be unfaithful as well as faithful, how is it a useful designation in terms of analyzing the significance of a work’s fidelity? Because Andrew’s “transformed” adaptations represent a category of adaptation that can represent either extreme of in/fidelity, it only perpetuates the reductive fidelity binary; a spectrum of fidelity with a clearer understanding of infidelity at the furthest end is required.

Enter fully adulterous adaptations, those narratives that retain only the vaguest sense of loyalty to *Frankenstein*. Examples of adulterous *Frankenstein* adaptations would include (1) tales of reanimation by a so-called “mad scientist” figure—such as the cult classic

The Rocky Horror Picture Show (1975, Jim Sharman), Stuart Gordon’s filmic adaptation of H.P. Lovecraft’s *Re-Animator* (1985), and the “Some Assembly Required” episode of *Buffy the Vampire Slayer* (1997, Bruce Seth Green)—(2) science-fiction variations on *Frankenstein* that focus on robots—such as Michael Crichton’s *Westworld* (1973), Ridley Scott’s *Blade Runner* (1982), and Tim Burton’s *Edward Scissorhands* (1990)—and (3) realizations of Victor’s aborted female creature—including Fritz Lang’s *Metropolis* (1927), John Hughes’s *Weird Science* (1985), and the experimental hypertext narrative *Patchwork Girl* (1995) from Shelley Jackson. As this list of examples demonstrates, adulterous adaptations may not be immediately recognizable as versions of a source text—primarily because they all distance themselves from the name “Frankenstein”—but they certainly maintain marital associations with other narrative and thematic aspects of *Frankenstein*, along with evoking other textual references, influences, and inspirations.

As the concept of the “faithful” adaptation is the degree of fidelity most understood by both audiences and film theorists alike, I will proceed directly to examples of promiscuous adaptation, focusing primarily on the efforts to transform Shelley’s *Frankenstein* from a novel to another narrative medium over the 100+ years between the tale’s original publication to the release of Whale’s film. This analytical survey will demonstrate both the power and the value of promiscuous adaptation, particularly in terms of evolving a text and ensuring its ongoing survival. While promiscuous adaptations of *Frankenstein* have continued to thrive after the Universal films of the 1930s—as with examples such as Jimmy Sangster’s *The Horror of Frankenstein* (1970), Roger Corman’s 1990 filmic adaptation of Aldiss’ *Frankenstein Unbound*, and Kiersten White’s feminist retelling *The Dark*

Descent of Elizabeth Frankenstein (2015)—I will focus later on adulterous adaptations from the 20th century of *Frankenstein*'s evolution.

The Promiscuous *Frankenstein*

Julie Grossman uses Shelley's designation of her novel as her own "hideous progeny" as a metaphor for the adaptation process in general, declaring *all* adaptations to be "monstrous" because they "are often born resisting the original desires of their sources" (2). This resistance inevitably recontextualizes the otherwise familiar work of art, and this "new context not only provides a unique perspective on its topic or theme but also models a way of recombining intellectual matter that sparks further creativity" (Grossman 5). In a similar vein, Glenn Jellenik's argument for a "Frankensteinian model for adaptation studies" (45) proposes that adaptive changes should be viewed as "inherently productive" (47), a productivity that, in my mind, enriches our understanding of the source material and the various cultural moments that saw the production of different versions of the text. As I will demonstrate, a chain of adaptations results in the disappearance of "vestigial" elements (Newell, *Expanding Adaptation Networks*, 12), to return to the evolutionary metaphor, and (hopefully) preserving the essence of the source material while making the text harder. I suggest promiscuous adaptive efforts represent just this kind of recontextualization, productivity, and evolution, as they update a text, translate it into a different medium, and make changes to appeal to a new or otherwise different audience.

While *Frankenstein* was popularized via "fifteen different stage adaptations before 1851" (Cutchins and Perry 2), the first—and perhaps the most significant variation—appeared just five years after the novel's publication: Richard Brinsley Peake's *Presumption; or, the Fate of Frankenstein*, performed at the English Opera House in the Strand on 18 July 1823. While this version maintains many direct ties to Shelley's work, Peake understandably had to adjust the content of the novel to facilitate its translation to the theater. Indeed, a truly "faithful" adaptation of the novel for the stage would have primarily consisted of Walton talking with the bedridden Victor for hours, with the Creature only showing up at the very end! Instead, Peake limited his focus to Frankenstein, Clerval, Elizabeth, William, and the Creature—along with DeLacey, Felix, Agatha, and Safie in somewhat different supporting roles. Furthermore, and understandably, he also limited the locations of the narrative, focusing exclusively on Geneva and its environs and jettisoning any action set in Ingolstadt, Chamonix, and England. And, as so many of the *Frankenstein* adaptations would also choose to do for the sake of truncation, the frame narrative involving Walton and his perilous journey across the Arctic ice is completely absent. Most of these promiscuous adjustments were necessitated by the change in medium, the genre of the narrative, and the limits of practical duration.

Peake's play demonstrates not only the necessity of promiscuous adaptation but also its value, for in addition to "translating" Shelley for a nineteenth-century stage, Peake also changed the trajectory of *Frankenstein* for future audiences, making adjustments that have become *more* familiar to audiences than the details of Shelley's novel.⁶ In the play, Walton has essentially been transformed into Fritz, a servant of the Frankenstein household who acts somewhat as a narrator of the story, a mediator to whom Victor (and others) explains things in conversation (like Walton) rather than via theatrical monologue, a source of comic relief, and the precursor to a host of (in)famous lab assistants. The cast

of characters is also mixed up a bit, with the De Lacey's having a more prominent role and an existing relationship with Frankenstein, most notably the blind patriarch of the family, who would reappear in various forms over the next two hundred years of filmic adaptations. Additionally, Victor has a "laboratory," rather than just his Ingolstadt apartment, where his "wonderful task ... will be animated" (Peake 367 & 369). Because the mysterious creation takes place off stage (as it does in the novel), the audience only receives Fritz's spirited description, along with Victor's cry of "It lives! It lives" (Peake 375), words that would eventually return as Clive's "It's alive! Alive!" declaration in Whale's film. The Creature is a giant force of nature, one who pursues Victor's brother William and murders his beloved—albeit Agatha De Lacey instead of Elizabeth, who is inexplicably presented as Victor's sister and betrothed of Clerval—but a Creature without a voice, perhaps the most insidious and lasting alteration to Shelley's original conception of Frankenstein's creation.

As in real life, promiscuity leads to infidelity, but this infidelity can also lead to longevity—at least in terms of a story's ongoing success and popularity. Peake was only the first of many playwrights who flirted with Shelley's hideous progeny; other significant early adaptations include Henry M. Milner's *The Demon of Switzerland and The Man and the Monster* (1823) and *Frankenstein; or, The Man and the Monster* (1826), Jean Toussaint Merle and Antoine Nicolas Béraud's *Le Monstre et le magicien* (1826),⁷ Richard and Barnabas Brough's *Frankenstein; or, The Model Man* (1849)—which notably retains Shelley's eloquent and sympathetic Creature—and Richard Butler and Henry Chance Newton's musical comedy *Frankenstein; or, The Vampire's Victim* (1887). Of these examples, Milner's second adaptation is perhaps the most noteworthy. First performed on 3 July 1826, Milner's *Frankenstein* features a number of promiscuous additions that have since become common staples of many of the films. As with Peake's play, Milner keeps the method of animation mysterious, having a comic servant—named "Strutt" in this version—spy on Frankenstein and relay the action verbally to the audience. The Creature is also depicted as a mute monster, but one who can be soothed by music, an element that has appeared in filmic adaptations (most notably *Young Frankenstein*). Finally, the play culminates with an angry mob of peasants, villagers, and soldiers who chase the Creature into the mountains to his doom.

Once film became a viable narrative medium, it wasn't long before Shelley's Creature found his way onto the screen, an even more drastic change in media that would require additional promiscuity. J. Searle Dawley made the first filmic adaptation of *Frankenstein* in 1910 for Edison Studios. Presented as "a liberal adaptation" on the title card, this almost 13-minute-long film understandably takes many liberties with Shelley's novel, jettisoning the frame narrative, most of the primary characters, and the majority of the story's action. Instead, it focuses on Victor's creation of life, being the first version of *Frankenstein* to depict the creation scene visually. In a twist that hasn't caught on with other *Frankenstein* adaptations (likely due to the lack of familiarity with Dawley's short film), Victor essentially *bakes* the Creature in a large oven, focusing on Shelley's allusions to alchemy rather than galvanism. This remarkable sequence—realized largely through a reversed motion effect—takes up roughly twenty percent of the film, demonstrating how central Dawley considered the monster's creation to Shelley's story (despite her having omitted it), and paving the way for almost every single film that would follow, in which

the creation scene would become the most central, the most elaborate, and the most memorable. Additionally, Frankenstein and his Creation are presented as doubles, shown at the end as literal reflections of each other.⁸ While this short film may not manifest the kind of intertextual influence the other early adaptations had on future adaptations, it does further illustrate how promiscuity in adaptation is often a necessity for different media and shorter durations, even when key elements from the source material remain intact.

Perhaps the most well-known stage adaptation of *Frankenstein* appeared in December 1927 when Hamilton Deane produced Peggy Webling's *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus* in Preston, Lancashire. As with the 19th-century stage adaptations of the tale, Webling jettisons Walton's frame narrative entirely, beginning her version with Frankenstein's triumphant creation, but she also makes additional promiscuous changes that would come to influence later adaptations: changing characters' names, bringing a lightning storm to the fore, making the Creature more childlike and sympathetic, and having the Creature drown an innocent young girl. Because of Webling's love of the name "Henry" and distaste for "Victor," she swapped the two men's forenames⁹—an alteration followed by Whale in his films—inexplicably changed "Elizabeth" to "Emilie Lavenza" and "Justine" to "Elizabeth," and bestowed the name "Frankenstein" upon the Creature himself (Webling 129).¹⁰ The play's direction notes include many references to flashing lightning and rolling thunder, a climatic detail present in most of the post-Whale *Frankenstein* films, such as *Young Frankenstein*, Tim Burton's *Frankenweenie* (2012), and Paul McGuigan's *Victor Frankenstein* (2015). Additionally, Henry and the Creature are dressed alike and presented as doubles, as in Dawley's film, and the Creature is more sympathetic, as in the Brough brother's play (see Graver 68). And, finally, this version of the Creature drowns a young girl—Henry's sister Katrine—albeit perhaps accidentally (as would be recreated with different relationships in Whale's film).

With these promiscuous changes in mind, one can see how strongly both Peake's and Webling's plays, in particular, influenced the writing and producing of Whale's 1931 film *Frankenstein*, but the adaptation is complicated as well as promiscuous. On the one hand, the opening credits sequence claims the film to be "from" the novel by "Mrs. Percy B. Shelley" and also "adapted from" Webling's play. On the other, however, John L. Balderston is credited with having created a "composition" upon which the film is *also* based, with the actual screenplay credit going to Garrett Fort and Francis Edwards Faragoh. No wonder the film lacks in terms of fidelity, with so many potential partners spoiling the sanctity of the film's marriage to Shelley's novel. With the term "adapted" only being applied to Webling's play, we can, however, see that source as the primary one to which Whale's film might be considered faithful, although that play is already a promiscuous adaptation of the novel. Whale's adaptation has no frame narrative, features a somewhat comedic lab assistant, has reversed character names, stars a hulking yet sympathetic (and largely mute) Creature, and includes the tragic death of a young girl, all elements drawn from Webling. Yet Whale's film also deploys the angry villagers of Milner's play, an on-screen depiction of the creative process as in Dawley's film (albeit galvanistic instead of alchemical), and the central role of lightning, as implied by Shelley and emphasized by Webling. Two other key moments from Whale's film—founded, in particular, upon Karloff's legendary performance—are drawn directly from Webling's play: the Creature's

fascination with the sun, as he “gaz[es] up into the sky, then slowly stretches out his hands,” and his lascivious desire for Henry’s betrothed, Elizabeth (Mae Clarke) (Webling 130 & 149). These promiscuous alterations, building on one another from textual generation to generation, produced what is arguably the most familiar version of *Frankenstein*. From Herman Munster (Fred Gwynne) in Ed Haas and Norm Liebmann’s *The Munsters* (1964–66) to the seasonal breakfast cereal “Franken Berry” (General Mills), most popular imaginings of Frankenstein’s Creature come from Whale; in other words, the Universal Studio’s film essentially represents the “weighty centre of the *Frankenstein* adaptation machine” (Cutchins and Perry 2), and all cinematic adaptations ever since have been inextricably linked to this foundational, if largely unfaithful, variation.

My purpose in tracking the promiscuous drift of *Frankenstein* has been to demonstrate the value of such infidelity in evolving a text to be more adaptable and to survive from year to year; indeed, promiscuous adaptation is essential for the ongoing success and longevity of an urtext. Like the process of mutation and evolution in the natural world, promiscuous adaptations survive because they are the “fittest,” at least in terms of cultural relevance, significance, and popularity. As these examples have demonstrated, minor alterations to a text—and in some cases, even major ones—recondition a text, almost as if by translation, to a different medium, culture, audience, or agenda. To take the biological metaphor even further, however, promiscuous mutations merely succeed in keeping the same literary “species” alive from (historical/cultural) environment to environment; it takes the more radical and liberal process of “adulterous adaptation” to create what is, in essence, a new “species” of text—or, at the very least, a new breed.¹¹ Promiscuity in adaptation leads to the discovery of variations that have increased staying power and serve future versions of stories better than aspects of the original—take the excising of Walton’s Arctic letters and frame narrative, for example, or the inclusion of a lab assistant for Frankenstein. In fact, promiscuous adaptation serves the antecedent text more than fidelity ever could, ensuring ongoing interest and a lasting legacy. The final section of this article is dedicated to even more extreme “adulterous” adaptations, new versions of *Frankenstein* that have experienced such fundamental changes in character, setting, plot, and purpose that they may cease to be easily recognizable as versions of *Frankenstein* at all.

The Adulterous *Frankenstein*

In their 2010 collection of essays on transformative adaptations, *Beyond Adaptation*, Phyllis Frus and Christy Williams make the case for radical alterations of source materials. Proposing a new way to look at adaptations that are drastically different from their textual antecedents, they suggest terms such as “metamorphosis,” “shape-shifting,” and “transformation” (Frus and Williams 1–3). Using the ubiquitous retelling of fairy tales as their initial example, they illustrate how transformed texts regularly (1) “challenge outdated attitudes,” (2) transpose the source work in a different genre, and (3) “create a new context” (Frus and Williams 2). While I would argue any adaptation can realize one or more of these transformational conditions, “adulterous” adaptations certainly do, as they defy fidelity to the point of betraying their source materials entirely, a betrayal that often leads to a “divorce” from the antecedent text. For Frus and Williams, these kinds of unfaithful textual practices should be called “transformations” rather than “adaptations,” re-visioned texts that are “drastically different from [their] source text[s],” resulting in essentially

independent works that have settings, characters, and plots that are “so different” that the new film “stands on its own” (3). While Frus and Williams’ sense of transformation would include what I am calling the promiscuous adaptations of texts, I consider their most compelling arguments to apply most relevantly to adulterous adaptations, considering their exemplars *Clueless* (1995, Amy Heckerling), *Wicked* (1995, Gregory Maguire), and *O Brother, Where Art Thou?* (2000, Joel and Ethan Coen) (3–4).¹²

Adulterous adaptations, then, are independent texts that need not rely upon their source inspirations to “work” on their own or for their viewing audiences. Grossman calls these kinds of radical departures “the most powerful adaptations,” those films that “are not passive conduits of the source text, but agents in their own right (10), and Newell suggests that “[t]hrough repetition over subsequent adaptations ... some elements begin to take on a life of their own” (*Expanding Adaptation Networks* 13). Adulterous adaptations stand on their own thanks to the many differences that have removed them from any overt loyalty to their source materials—but not entirely: connections continue to exist, largely in terms of character, story, and plot, in much the same way a divorced couple stays connected, however loosely, due to shared children, extended family, business interests, etc For example, *The Rocky Horror Picture Show* lacks the title, main characters, and plot of Shelley’s novel, but it nonetheless features an artificially created being and a character named “Dr Frank-N-Furter” (Tim Curry). Another way to distinguish between promiscuous texts and adulterous ones is to think of the former as being “based on” a pre-existing text, whereas the latter are primary “inspired by” the antecedent (Frus and Williams 5)—or, as in the case of the films in the Marvel Cinematic Universe, being simply “based on characters created by.” In other words, the relationship between faithful adaptations, promiscuous adaptations, and adulterous adaptations is largely one of degree (and a potentially subjective one at that).

In terms of the Frankenstein Network of texts—and as illustrated above—adulterous examples usually abandon the title and character name of “Frankenstein” completely, making substantial changes to the formal elements of Shelley’s novel to focus on borrowing concepts, themes, tone, and the general story instead. I see most adulterous transformations of *Frankenstein* landing in one of three categories: (1) stories that focus on a misguided scientist’s efforts to create male-coded life from inanimate matter, (2) stories that focus on a misguided scientist’s efforts to create human-coded beings from cybernetics and technological components, and (3) stories that focus on a misguided scientist’s efforts to create *female*-coded life from inanimate matter or from cybernetics and technological components. A primary example of the first type is Gordon’s cinematic reimagining of H. P. Lovecraft’s 1922 tale, *Re-Animator*; a classic tale of “robotic” Frankensteins is Scott’s dystopian film *Blade Runner*, itself a reimagining of Philip K. Dick’s 1988 story “Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep”; and, finally, a recognizable exploration of the “Bride of Frankenstein” would include Hughes’s teen-sex-romp *Weird Science*. All of these example texts demonstrate the ability for a transformed, adulterous adaptation to work on its own—often becoming an adapted source text in its own right—while nonetheless owing something fundamental to the legacy of *Frankenstein*.

Gordon’s dark and campy *Re-Animator* (adapted by Dennis Paoli and William Norris) represents not only an adulterous reworking of Shelley’s novel but also a retelling of *another* Frankenstein offshoot, Lovecraft’s “Herbert West—Reanimator,” illustrating Fru and

Williams's claim that "[m]any transformations work from multiple texts, not just a single one" (5). While Gordon's West is clearly no Victor Frankenstein, he certainly demonstrates the myopic zeal and hubris of his literary ancestor, especially as played on screen by Jeffrey Combs. Indeed, one of West's first lines in the film is "I gave him life," firmly establishing thematic links to Whale's *Frankenstein*, if not Shelley's novel. Granted, unlike Victor, West is a hyperbolic "mad scientist" rather than simply an obsessed college student, ranting and raving about life after death, reanimating a dead cat, and unwisely performing experiments on humans as well—including himself. Rather than embrace the galvanistic approach to reanimation made famous by Whale's films, however, West turns to neuro-logical chemicals, injecting the brains of his subjects with a mysterious, green-glowing liquid. Other characters populate the film as well, each evoking various personalities from the *Frankenstein* legacy: Dan Cain (Bruce Abbott), who, rather than filling the role of Victor's best friend Henry, seems to be more of an assistant figure, like Peake's Fritz; Elizabeth, who has been replaced by Megan Halsey (Barbara Crampton), Dan's girlfriend; and the true antagonist of the movie, Dr Carl Hill (David Gale), who evokes the character of Dr Pretorius (Ernest Thesiger) from Whale's *The Bride of Frankenstein* (1935). In other words, *Re-Animator* is a complex, palimpsestic, intertextual adaptation of multiple sources, one with a core "essence" aligned more with Shelley's *Frankenstein* than with Lovecraft's story.

By approaching Gordon's film through the lens of the Frankenstein Complex, one can see how it fulfills the requirements of transformational adaptation, as outlined by Frus and Williams. The film's cruelty and violence—manifested through unethical experimentation, sexual assault, and the violation of agency, not to mention substantial blood and gore—challenge the more conservative approaches to other Frankensteinian texts. This emphasis on body horror and cinematic camp also, I would say, transposes *Frankenstein* into a different genre—more schlock horror than literary Gothic. And, finally, a new context is created in terms of a contemporary hospital, a basement morgue, and scientific methods and innovations. Yet despite these notable transformations, *Re-Animator* is still operating in Shelley's literary tradition in terms of the core story. For example, West does successfully reanimate not one but three male corpses, all with disastrous results: Melvin (Peter Kent), who goes on a violent rampage; Dean Halsey (Robert Sampson), who ends up little more than a walking vegetable (although he does come through in the end); and the dastardly Hill, who proves more sinister and wicked as a reanimate than he was when alive. West is ultimately overwhelmed by the hoard of zombies he has helped to create (pushing the film into yet another subgenre), reinforcing the morality tale at the end of Shelley's novel, which leaves just Dan to bring his lost love Megan back to life—a formal nod to *The Bride of Frankenstein* at the end of the film.

The fusion of *Frankenstein* with 20th-century science fiction has produced a host of narratives exploring the ethics and risks associated with the creation of artificial life, life grounded not in natural processes, chemistry, or biology, but in robotics and cybernetics. While many fine examples of such films exist, Scott's *Blade Runner* remains perhaps the most well known. Only very loosely based on Dick's short story (an extreme example of adulterous adaptation if ever there were one), Scott's noir classic follows the efforts of a dystopian police officer—Deckard (Harrison Ford), the "Blade Runner" of the film's title—who is tasked with identifying artificial humans—Replicants—and "retiring" them

permanently. In contrast to *Frankenstein*, then, Deckard is not fulfilling the role of Victor at all; that honor is shared by a number of characters who work for the powerful and mysterious Tyrell Corporation. The overall story and plot structure of *Blade Runner* depart even more from *Frankenstein* than *Re-Animator* does, with its connections to Shelley's novel lying almost entirely in terms of the central concept (the artificial creation of life), the ethics surrounding such creative processes, and the disastrous consequences that ultimately result by neglecting and even abusing the resulting creations. Additionally, the film represents an evolution of scale, an adaptive escalation common among sequels (if we chose to consider sequels a form of adaptation), with not only more than one Creature, but also more than one Victor.

Blade Runner definitely transposes its source into a different genre—moving from Shelley's proto-science-fiction Gothicism to Dick's post-war science fiction to Scott's sci-fi noir—but it also challenges attitudes and creates a new context. This version of Shelley's story features not a single misguided creator but a nefarious corporation that seeks to replicate humanity through the development of beings that exist in the liminal space between alive and artificial, autonomous and enslaved. To keep this creative power in check, the Tyrell Corporation compartmentalizes the process, giving no one individual total access—"I only make the eyes!," biomechanical engineer Chew (James Hong) famously cries as his only defense. Nevertheless, the film does have a primary Victor figure: Tyrell (Joe Turkel), the head of this "Corporate Frankenstein." He thinks the key to creating superior Replicants is to give them artificial memories, to make them think they are human and not merely machines, and to imbed an "expiration date" to shut them down before they can become *too* human. The context here is clearly a dystopian one, a world in which corporations have taken the place of God and can determine the fate of a new race of beings. As in *Frankenstein*, the representative "Creature" Batty (Rutger Hauer) both seeks an audience with his creator (Tyrell) and questions the ethics of making life for the sole purpose of enslavement. Indeed, Batty's eloquent monologue at the film's climax, shared with Deckard during a rainstorm, certainly evokes the Creature's tortuous pleadings to Victor on the frozen Mer de Glace glacier in Shelley's novel.

The third category of adulterous *Frankenstein* adaptations relies upon a central motif only alluded to by Shelley—presented as a possibility, not a narrative reality: the successful creation of a *female* being. Beginning with Whale's sequel to his *Frankenstein*, *The Bride of Frankenstein* explores what might have happened had Victor/Henry followed through with his promise to his Creature to provide a mate.¹³ Yet the very title of the film—echoed at the Bride's (Elsa Lanchester) creation by Pretorius—suggests an ambiguity explored by promiscuous and adulterous adaptations alike: Is the Bride intended for the Creature or for Frankenstein himself? A classic if perhaps unorthodox example of the story aborted by Shelley can be found in Hughes's *Weird Science* (adapted by Hughes, Al Feldstein, and William M. Gaines). Unlike *Re-Animator* and *Blade Runner*, Hughes's film has some overt references to *Frankenstein*: the opening credits music ("Weird Science," by Oingo Boingo) samples Clive's famous "It's alive" cry, and the two ersatz Frankensteins (unpopular nerds Gary [Anthony Michael Hall] and Wyatt [Ilan Mitchell-Smith]) open the movie by watching the creation scene from Whale's film. Rather than dig up the corpses of young women, however, the two sex-starved losers use a computer to create the "perfect woman," in terms of both physical appearance and cognitive ability. By illegally accessing a military

computer system, they are (inexplicably) able to develop a hyper-sophisticated virtual woman in cyberspace, a woman with physical, intellectual, and even magical properties that they (inexplicably) fuse with a Barbie doll to give life to a real, flesh-and-blood woman (Kelly LeBrock).

Of the three case study examples presented here, *Weird Science* represents the most extreme and least faithful transposition of the source material in terms of genre, but, like the other two films discussed above, it also responds to new attitudes and creates a new context. Unlike earlier versions of *Frankenstein* that merely allude to the sexual potential of a female creature, *Weird Science* embraces the teenage-sexual revolution of the 1980s (as explored extensively by Hughes in his other films). The social/historical context is clearly a tremendous departure from the 1930s, and the film challenges outdated attitudes concerning not only sexual liberation but also the portrayal of a female character. Gary and Wyatt name their creation “Lisa,”¹⁴ and while she is clearly superior to her creators in every single way, she remains little more than an enslaved “sex-bot”; in fact, she tells a shy Wyatt, “You made me; you control me,” emphasizing her subservience and the misogynistic fantasy she fulfills in the narrative. Indeed, Lisa’s sole purpose is to serve her creators, not only satisfying their sexual curiosity but also transforming their social lives and high-school status for the better. Her methods, however, might be considered “monstrous”: she forces Wyatt to have a raucous house party, threatens Gary’s parents with physical violence, and freezes Wyatt’s grandparents in a cupboard, all before unleashing a rampaging biker gang upon the partygoers. But her efforts are all in the perceived service of her creators. In this regard, Lisa acts perhaps more like a misguided genie than a Frankensteinian creation; indeed, at the end of the movie, once the two boys finally have girlfriends, she disappears in a puff of smoke before magically undoing all the damage of the former night, her *raison d’être* efficiently fulfilled.

These examples of adulterous *Frankenstein* adaptations illustrate the broad and far-reaching potential of more liberal transformations of source texts, especially when those transformations draw upon already transformed adaptations. While adulterous adaptations may preserve some obvious and direct links to their narrative antecedents—such as the insertion of Whale’s *Frankenstein* directly into *Weird Science*—others need draw merely upon the more ephemeral aspects of the story in question: themes, tropes, ethics, and ideas, along with specific turns at the same story elements, beats, and plots. Unlike adaptations that attempt to recreate the original material with recognizable fidelity, both promiscuous and adulterous adaptations concern themselves primarily with the potential abstraction of “essence,” the core of the story that *makes* it a unique story, a core that can be reconfigured, repackaged, and re-presented into almost limitless variations on the same theme. By recognizing the variable degrees to which a text derives its narrative identity from *Frankenstein*, audiences and scholars alike position themselves better to analyze, interpret, and understand the adaptation(s) and its cultural significance.

Conclusion

I chose *Frankenstein* as the focus of this theoretical proposal due to its extensive presence in literary, cinematic, and popular culture, but the concept of faithful, promiscuous, and adulterous adaptation (especially in terms of a spectrum of fidelity) can be used to enlighten the study of other text systems, be they Austen’s *Pride and Prejudice* (1813), Bram

Stoker's *Dracula* (1897), L. Frank Baum's *The Wonderful Wizard of Oz* (1900), or any number of famous fairy tales and their Disney-fied variations. While the consideration of similarities between an adaptation and its primary source will always be essential to adaptation theory, the *differences* ultimately produce the heartiest subjects of analysis, and having a somewhat "sliding scale" of fidelity can only give valuable structure and methodological approaches to such investigations. Furthermore, while I have limited myself to an admittedly subjective cluster of example *Frankenstein* adaptations, one can easily identify various additional examples, both in the past and coming in the near future. Indeed, as both a fan and scholar of *Frankenstein*, I am eagerly awaiting both Guillermo del Toro's (implicitly promiscuous) *Frankenstein* (2025) and Maggie Gyllenhaal's (implicitly adulterous) *The Bride* (2026). How will these two reimaginings of Shelley's novel, Whale's film, and the hundreds of other *Frankensteins* stack up, and what influence will they, in turn, exert on even more *Frankenstein* adaptations in the future? And there will be more adaptations—Shelley's hideous progeny has certainly proven its longevity—be they faithful, promiscuous, or adulterous.

Conflicts of interest: none declared.

ENDNOTES

¹Even though Whale's film is black and white, the trademarked gray-green makeup used by Universal to achieve Boris Karloff's pale skin became iconic, and color versions of Karloff's look have been green ever since (Higgs).

²Even though Andrew was writing in the 1980s, I find his matrices continue to be useful in analyzing adaptations, especially with the theoretical updating I am performing here.

³See Mark O'Thomas's "Turning Japanese: Translation, Adaptation, and the Ethics of Trans-National Exchange" (in *Adaptation Studies: New Approaches*, edited by Christa Albrecht-Crane and Dennis Cutchins, Fairleigh Dickinson UP, 2010, pp. 46–60) for a detailed discussion of different kinds of adaptive processes.

⁴The series was begun by writer Gary Friedrich (along with penciler and collaborator Mike Ploog), who was later replaced by Doug Moench (#12–17) and then Bill Mantlo (#18).

⁵Thanks to my colleague Todd Robert Petersen for helping me coin these adaptive designations.

⁶See Jellenik's "A Frankensteinian Model for Adaptation Studies" for a detailed discussion and analysis of Peake's play as an adaptation of Shelley's *Frankenstein*.

⁷Titled *The Monster and The Magician: Or, The Fate of Frankenstein* in English.

⁸The 2011 Royal National Theatre production of *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus*—adapted by Nick Dear and directed by Danny Boyle—explored this doubling idea by having actors Benedict Cumberbatch and Jonny Lee Miller alternate the roles of Victor and the Creature from performance to performance.

⁹See Graver, Note 40, "From Peake to Whale," 75.

¹⁰Whether "Frankenstein" refers to the Creature or the Creator has become something of a long-running joke in popular culture, and Webling certainly makes a case for both.

¹¹See Frus and Williams, "Case for Transformation," 3, for more on this Darwinian analogy of adaptation.

¹²*Clueless* is inspired by Jane Austin's 1815 novel *Emma*; the novel *Wicked* is primarily inspired by Victor Flemming and King Vidor's 1939 movie musical adaptation of L. Frank Baum's 1900 novel, *The Wonderful Wizard of Oz*; and *O Brother, Where Art Thou?* is only very loosely related to Homer's epic poem *Odyssey*.

¹³I have explored the failure of filmmakers to provide the "Bride of Frankenstein" with an autonomous existence and feminist story in my "The Subaltern Brides of Frankenstein: Liberating Shelley's Unrealized Female Creature on Screen" (in *Creolizing Frankenstein*, edited by Michael Paradiso-Michau, Rowman & Littlefield International, 2024, pp. 83–99), although Yorgos Lanthimos's *Poor Things* (2023, adapted from Alasdair Gray's 1992 novel) certainly comes closer.

¹⁴Curiously, Diablo Cody would choose this same name for the titular character in Zelda Williams's, *Lisa Frankenstein* (2024), albeit in reference to the creator and not the created.

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